

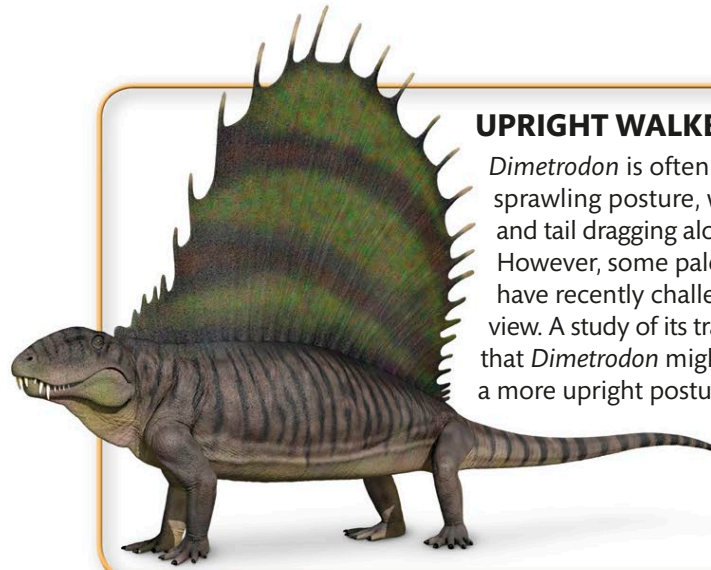
Heated debate

Dimetrodon's sail was supported by bony, rodlike extensions on its back. In the past, some scientists suggested that the sail would have increased the surface area of *Dimetrodon*'s body, allowing it to warm up faster under the sun. However, most paleontologists now consider this to be incorrect and think that the sail was probably used to attract mates.

Injuries on the tips of some *Dimetrodon* spines suggest this part of the sail was not covered by skin.

UPRIGHT WALKER?

Dimetrodon is often shown in a sprawling posture, with its belly and tail dragging along the ground. However, some paleontologists have recently challenged this view. A study of its tracks suggests that *Dimetrodon* might have had a more upright posture.



AT A GLANCE

- **LENGTH** 5½–15 ft (1.7–4.6 m)
- **DIET** Carnivore
- **LIVED** 295–272 MYA
- **HABITAT** Wetlands and deltas



Caninelike fangs